back on Lumpu, which he reached at 1 p.m. the next day. By then, the leading elements of 2 Rajput, exhausted from their 400-kilometre journey from the plains, were beginning to arrive.

Dalvi's reconnaissance had helped him arrive at the firm conclusion that 'Dhola was militarily useless, indefensible and dominated by Chinese positions and located in a trap. It had poor approaches, no fields of fire and no mutual support. The Hathung-la and Karpo-la 1 routes could not be defended by one battalion. A secure base for operations was an elementary precaution but could not be established, as our Lines of Communication and the Lumpu dropping zone were vulnerable to a counter thrust. It was impossible even for a brigade to provide its own firm base and assault troops.

'The Dhola area was unsuitable as a forming-up place for mounting any form of attack against the intruding Chinese. I could see the three tiers of Chinese defence positions, the first was on the river bank opposite our own troops; the second half way up the Thagla slopes on Paitsai Spur and the third on the crest of the ridge.' To have any chance against the network of machine guns deployed on the forward slopes and the mortars on the reverse slopes, 7 Brigade would need massive artillery support. At the present time, never mind artillery guns, the brigade did not even have heavy mortars.

So far, the interaction between Indian and Chinese troops had been limited to verbal threats, each trying to convince the other to withdraw from their territory. At times, they were even friendly enough for them to exchange cigarettes across Bridges 1 and 2. Dalvi himself had tried speaking to the Chinese sentries at Bridge 3. This state of affairs was unlikely to last, and the peace was broken on 20 September when a Chinese soldier on the south bank near Bridge 2 threw a grenade at the Indian sentry post a few yards away. In the ensuing firing, two Chinese soldiers were killed and two others wounded, while on the Indian side, five men were wounded. With two armies dug in and facing each other across the Nam Ka Chu, this incident could not be classified as yet another border incident. It was just a matter of time before the situation became very serious.

By 22 September, Krishna Menon had left for New York where he was busy at the United Nations. The prime minister was also not available, so a meeting presided over by the minister of state for defence, Kotha Raghuramaiah, was held. The COAS, Thapar, gave an update of the